

Prime Time Prima Donnas

Melodrama, mascara and mush. A look at TV's winning women.



**PRIME TIME SOAP
OPERAS ON INDIAN
TELEVISION**

by SHOMA MUNSHI

Routledge

Price: Rs 595

Pages: 312

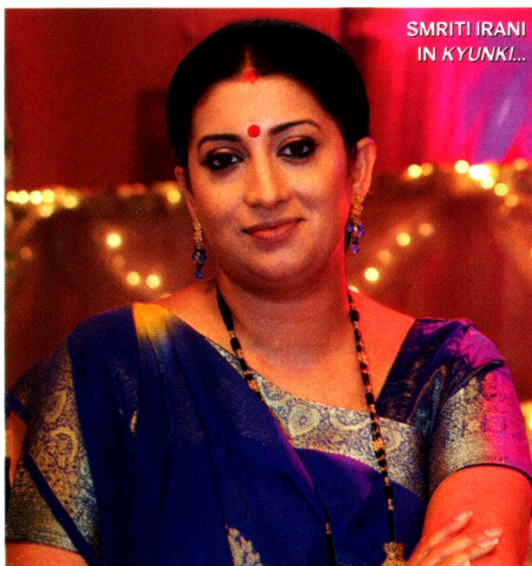
| By Kaveree Bamzai |

Do auraton ke beech grilled sandwich bane tumhe 25 saal ho gaye (you've been sandwiched between two women for the past 25 years), says one woman accused of bigamy to another bigamous man in *Kyunki Saas Bhi Kabhi Bahu Thi*. A slap resounds thrice, the camera does a swish pan shot, accompanied by loud music and after the principal actors are coloured in various shades of red, green and blue, the scene is eventually frozen, in black and white. Yet these are not the only miracles that have happened on prime time TV. Women have lived to be 250 years old. Men have come back from the dead, with amnesia, if not different faces. Diyas have almost never run out of oil. And every soap has ultimately been based on the *Ramayan* and *Mahabharat*, only Ravana has usually been an evil sister-in-law dressed in a shimmering sari with two layers of foundation and waterproof mascara. Difficult to keep a straight face, is it? Not when you realise that over 100 million people watch this, every day. Or did at any rate, because even though the Tulsi-Parvati hegemony may have ended on TV, women, especially those in distress, continue to reign in the television pantheon.

If only *Prime Time Soap Operas on Indian Television* stuck to such delicious detail, even drowning itself and its reader in a mountain of minutiae. How Eka Kapoor's mother Shobha spent Rs 2-4 crore on each indoor set, and Rs 1 crore on saris and lehengas in one month for one show alone. Or how a rain sequence requires at least four tankers with

20,000 litres of water and stars can make up to Rs 50,000 a day. Sadly, it doesn't. This is one of those books where the bibliography and notes cross-referencing the work of other scholars are longer than the original text. And where even the most banal comments, such as the *Ramayan* containing "idealised models of familial bonds to which even a modernised Hindu pays lip service", are attributed to other academics. The book lives too much in the moment, which is a pity in the ever changing television space, where a new female star is crowned every month. If it is the child bride of *Balika Vadhu* for one hot second, then it is the mouthy, mushy, maverick Rakhi Sawant of *Rakhi ka Swayamvar*, or the vanilla bride, Akshara, of *Yeh Rishta Kya Kehlata Hai* for another. The book does make several incontestable points. About TV femininity being intertwined with notions of nation and religion. About the men being wusses, or in extreme cases, outright dunces. And the soap being the ultimate in a haute bourgeois lifestyle, the kind of consumerist neverland once celebrated only by Bollywood.

But there is no sense of how we got here. Was Zee TV's *Tara* the television ancestor of the romantic and independent-minded Perna on *Kasautii Zindagii Kay*? Was the strong-willed Ketaki of *Khandan* the prototype for Tulsi on *Kyunki* who did not hesitate to kill her own son? And is there a little bit of *Hum Log*'s Majhli in every Tanu from *Kahaani Ghar Ghar Kii* who is shown going off the rails? Shoma Munshi doesn't analyse how the smart, well-spoken Shanti of the eponymous serial and Kalyani of *Udaan* gave way to women who were almost always restricted to their homes. She does hint at a yearning for nostalgia in a society in the midst of a rapid transformation, but doesn't develop it further. A little like a soap opera without closure. ■



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**VIOLENCE,
MARTYRDOM
AND PARTITION:
A DAUGHTER'S
TESTIMONY**

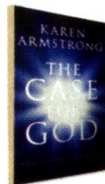
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